A Tiny Tail

Current version: 1.1
Status: In Production
GDD Lead: Luísa de Farias Moreira



(Image 1.0)

Team Members

Direction:

Beatriz Brayner & Luísa Moreira

Programming:

Gabriel Pereira, Henrique José, José Paulo Meira, Renan Albuquerque

Audio-visual:

Beatriz Brayner & Luísa Moreira

Scriptwriting:

Beatriz Brayner, Luísa Moreira, Gabriel Pereira

Game Design

Concept statement:

A Tiny Tail combines the cozy atmosphere of a welcoming world with the unpredictable progression of a 2D roguelite. Master precise mechanics, assemble builds with modular prosthetics on each run, and chat with charismatic NPCs — whose gossip reveals the secrets to reaching the legendary Cheese Kingdom.

In a vibrant 2D universe, you jump and fight to guide a fearless little mouse to the Cheese Kingdom while facing a hostile environment that demands quick reflexes. Its key distinguishing feature is a modular mechanic in which each robotic arm unlocks an entirely new platforming style.

Gameplay:

After starting the game, the player will be presented with a menu containing the following options: (New Game, Load Saved Game, and Options). The “New Game” option starts a new game from the beginning. “Load Saved Game” allows the player to return to a point previously saved by them. “Options” provides access to sound options and settings.

Upon selecting the New Game option, an introductory cutscene will begin, followed by a tutorial covering the basic movement and combat mechanics.

After that, the first level begins, where the player chooses which arm they want to play with and embarks on a journey to face the enemies ahead (including geckos, mosquitoes, among others).

The game's movement and combat will revolve around a system of different prosthetic arms with different functions that will drastically change how the player interacts with the levels.

The economy system features gold coins (temporary currency used for upgrades during a run), earned at the end of each room, and silver coins (permanent currency that carries over between runs and is used to permanently upgrade the protagonist), earned after each boss fight won. (The economy is under discussion)

Gameplay Loop:

- Core loop: Fight enemies -> Advance through levels -> Receive upgrades -> Unlock new areas (Image 1.1)
- Short-term (moment-to-moment): Agile 2D platforming movement with precise controls (distinctive and responsive game feel). The player chooses their initial prosthesis as an attack weapon, runs, jumps, and fights hostile creatures.
- Medium-term (session): Clear challenging rooms on the procedurally generated map, interact with charismatic NPCs, and collect gossip and clues. Each run begins with the choice of a prosthetic weapon arm, allowing players to test new builds, unlock abilities, and accumulate resources in the cozy village.
- Long-term (meta): Unlock and master the entire arsenal of starting prostheses, permanently upgrade the character, and make their way through new rooms. Connect the stories and gossip heard throughout multiple attempts to unravel the great mystery of the Cheese Kingdom.
- Player verbs: Activate, Attack, Dodge, Upgrade, Interact.
- Progression: Based on player skill and power. The tutorial ends after the protagonist leaves the basement

Design pillars:

- Gameplay must be fair: Failures are ALWAYS the player's own fault.
- The core of the gameplay is rapid adaptation. Switching arms should not be merely cosmetic; it should radically change how the mouse interacts with the world.
- Whispered worldbuilding: The story is not told through massive blocks of text (cutscenes), but through gossip, warnings, and secrets whispered by NPCs. The ONLY exception is the opening cutscene.

Controls (Keyboard):

- Movement: A-D
- Menu: Esc
- Jump: Spacebar
- Skill: Q
- Attack: LMB (Left Mouse Button)
- Interact: E

Obstacles and Enemies:

- Infected Rats: Two attacks. The first consists of a medium-range acid spit projectile (the spit causes poisoning), and the second is a melee attack.
- Beehive + Insects: A swarm of insects that can only be stopped by destroying the beehive. Individual insects have very low health.
- Flies: A melee attack consisting of a sting.
- Geckos: A medium-range projectile attack consisting of a tongue lash.
- Spider: Fires a web projectile that applies a slowness effect for a short period of time.
- Scorpion: A fast melee attack that causes poisoning if the target is hit by its stinger (weakening the target so that it takes more damage from the next attack).
- Rat Glue: Causes slowness while in contact with the surface.
- Mousetrap: An obstacle that takes 2 seconds to snap shut, but getting caught in it causes instant death.

PJ’s Skills:

- Needle Prosthesis: Lower damage, more agile. Special ability = dash
- Grappling Hook Prosthesis: Ranged weapon. Special ability = grapple
- Hammer Prosthesis: Higher damage, slower. Special ability = shockwave

Upgrades:

- Extra Life: Upon dying, the player only loses one life and instantly respawns with approximately 30% of their total health.
- More Damage: Deals 1.25x more damage, based on the current damage.
- More Speed: Gains 1.25x more speed, based on the current speed.
- Super Mouse: Does not die instantly when caught in a mousetrap.
- Health Regeneration: Regenerates health after going 10 seconds without taking damage.
- Invincibility: Gains 1.5 seconds of invincibility after taking damage.

Standard Market Options:

- Genre: 2D Platformer, Roguelite
- Target Audience: Young adults and adults (ages 16 to 35), Fans of cozy aesthetics, PC gamers
- Unique Selling Point: Your modular prostheses serve as both weapons and traversal tools. Switching arms changes your attributes and rewrites the rules of level navigation, turning each run into a new way to explore the world.
- ST Cog (Short-Term Cognizance): Memorizing the range of an attack, calculating the timing of a jump onto a moving platform, identifying the correct timing to switch prosthetic arms when facing a sudden obstacle.
- LT Cog (Long-Term Cognizance): Connecting clues and scattered stories shared by NPCs to understand the world's overarching narrative, planning which prosthetic arm to upgrade or focus on for future challenges.
- Brazilian Age Rating (ClassInd): Not recommended for children under 13 (13)
- International Age Rating (ESRB): Not recommended for children under 13 / Teen (T)
- Monetization: Free-to-play
- Programming Language: GDScript

Game Systems:

Player-focused:

- **Dodging and Combat** (Presses dodge/attack button -> Checks whether the ability is off cooldown -> Immediate dodge/attack animation and damage application)
- **Prosthesis Ability** (Presses ability button -> Validates the type of prosthesis equipped and checks whether the ability is off cooldown -> Immediate ability animation and damage application)
- **NPC Interaction** (Presses interact button -> Checks the order of the text to be displayed -> Opens the text box)
- **Upgrade** (Presses interact button -> Calculates attributes based on the selected upgrade -> Triggers confirmation sound and applies the new attribute values)

Internal:

- **Enemy State** (Player's x/y position relative to the enemy -> If the player is within the enemy's line of sight, it transitions from "Patrol" to "Attack" -> Change in enemy behavior)
- **Room Generation** (Player crosses the transition door into a new room -> The algorithm selects a pre-built room template and randomly selects the enemy spawn table -> Instant loading of the new scene)
- **Upgrade** (Checks the current value corresponding to the desired attribute -> Calculates the attribute change based on the item received -> Base attribute change)

Scope & Vertical Slice:

MVP (what the loop needs to function):

- Screen, characters, prostheses, and enemies.

Desejável (what improves the game and is included if time allows):

- Different effects caused by enemies, highly elaborate animations, and a greater number of levels.

Out of Scope:

- Open world, Multiplayer, and Combat with multiple weapons simultaneously.

Risks & Plan B:

RISK	PROBABILITY	IMPACT	PLAN B
3 playable levels	High	High	1 level only
Original artwork with animation	High	High	Simplified artwork
Different power-ups and multiplier effects	Medium	High	Only the essentials

Story & Setting:

A Tiny Tail takes place in a microscopic world where rodent society has been split in two. Long ago, the Rat Kingdom was a prosperous civilization that fell apart due to an outbreak of plague that consumed the minds of the rats, turning them irrational and violent. The survivors fled to the basement, settling in a small town called Squeak-ton. According to an ancient prophecy, a hero mouse will venture forth in search of glory and bring a cure to those lost to the plague, and that hero is our protagonist.

The game will be set inside a house, with a friendly and cozy atmosphere and a predominantly warm color palette. We will use diegetic and environmental storytelling to build the narrative.

- Emotional Impact: Comfort in failure, Wonder at the scale of real-world objects, Mastery and precision (skill)
- Cultural Impact: A reference in the Cozy-Roguelite genre, Accessibility to the genre (an entry point for players who avoid roguelites)

Desired experience:

- Player's Role in the World: Chosen hero, destined to leave their town and find the lost Cheese Kingdom.
- Target Emotions: Fun and Curiosity.
- What Fantasy the Game Provides: In A Tiny Tail, the fantasy is the freedom to face challenges in different ways and unravel the kingdom's mysteries.
- What Keeps the Player Interested: The different ways to progress through levels using prostheses and the story told by NPCs.

Visual design:

- **Directional Statement:** A tiny universe depicted within the real world
- **Moodboard:** (Image 1.2)
- **Message Through Visual Design:** Small creatures are capable of great things
- **Color Palette:** Cozy colors (yellow, brown, blue)
- **Pixel Art Scale:** 48px x 48px
- **Access to the artwork**

Sound design:

- **Directional Statement:** "Springs, metals, and metallic stitches shape the rhythm of our journey."
- **Message Through Audio Design:** Convey the feeling of a tiny world within a cozy home, where the danger posed by infected rats is real and frantic, but the player's presence with their scrap-built prostheses brings control, precision, and a touch of mechanical nostalgia.
- **Main Instruments Used:** Melodic and harmonic (Ukulele, Acoustic Guitar, Kalimba, Music Box) / Percussion and Effects (Soft Synthesizers)
- **Sound Moments:** 100ms hit confirmation, 100ms damage taken, Upgrades.

Design references:

Graphics:

- **It Takes Two:** The aesthetic of a small universe depicted in the real world
- **The Secret World of Arrietty:** A practical universe with small things.
- **Katana Zero:** Graphic proportions and animation style

Sound:

- **Toby Fox:** Use of motifs and synthesizers

Gameplay style:

- **Hades:** The upgrade system and weapon selection system
- **Dead Cells:** Adaptation of *roguelites* to a 2D system
- **Hollow Knight:** The combat system

Code Developement

Prototype 1.0:

Date (Start - End (D/M/Y)): 8/10/2026 - 27/10/2026
People Responsible: Gabriel Pereira, Luísa Moreira
Status: Finished
Changes:

- + Added Jump
- + Added Horizontal Movement
- + Added Jump and Idle Animations

*Note: Open-source assets were used for all other elements of the prototype. All credit goes to their respective authors

Prototype 1.1:

Date (Start - End (D/M/Y)): 27/10/2026 -
People Responsible: Gabriel Pereira, Henrique José, Luísa Moreira, Beatriz Brayner
Status: In progress
Changes:

- + Added X
- - Removed Y

Audio-visual Developement

Version 1.0:

Date (Start - End (D/M/Y)): 08/10/2026 -
People Responsible: Luísa Moreira
Status: In progress
Changes:

- + Animated idle sprite
- + Animated jump sprite

Playtests

Playtest 01:

Version: 1.0
Date (D/M/Y): 27/10/2026
People Responsible: Beatriz Brayner
Findings:

Pre-test:

- The jump animation should be modified and split into two (falling and rising)
- The sprites look very beautiful
- The movement feels pleasant

Post-test:

- The jump should be lower to allow for a double-jump
- The jump animation should be modified and split into two (falling and rising)
- The movement is very slow

Playtest 02:

Version:
Date (D/M/Y):
People Responsible:
Findings:

Pre-test:

- I think X

Post-test:

- I identified X

Image 1.1:

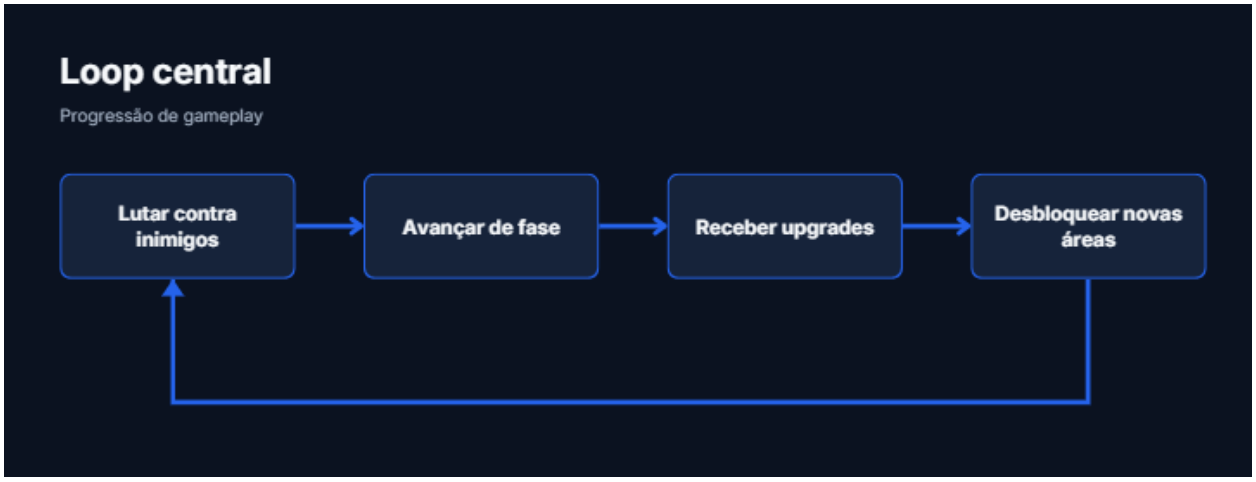
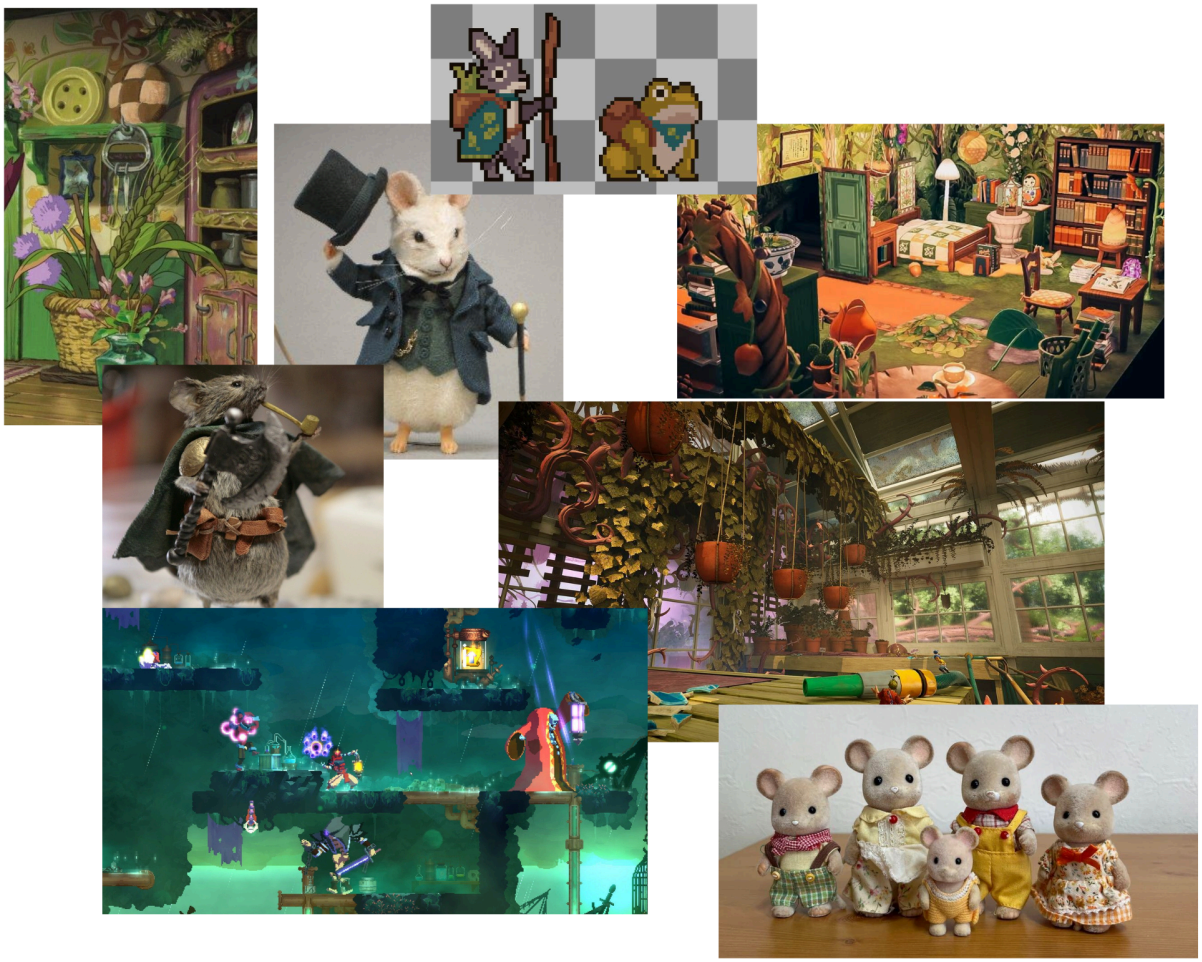


Image 1.2:



Credits:

- The Secret World of Arrietty

- It Takes Two
- Dead Cells
- Taxidermied rats by artist Lea Mai Nguyen
- Sylvanian Families
- Pixel art by an unknown artist on Pinterest